

OUTREACH TEARDOWNS

The cold outreach playbook

An audit of 201 of my own cold outreach threads, the five things that broke it, and the system I rebuilt.

201 threads read **0** positive replies **1** real conversation **18** auto-replies
35+ said no **50+** wrong audience **70+** silence

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2026-09

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I sent 200+ cold emails and got zero replies. Here's the system I rebuilt.

Most people fix cold outreach by rewriting the email. I counted instead, every thread, one by one. The email was not the main problem.

Het Soni · outreach.soniconsultancyservices.com/articles/the-audit/

Zero replies makes a clean headline. It also flatters me.

People did reply. 35+ of them wrote back to say no: a real person, typing it out. 18 more “replies” came from out-of-office bots. What never came back, across 201 threads, was a single positive reply to a cold email.

I know the exact numbers because I stopped guessing. I went through my Gmail, pulled every outreach thread I'd starred, all 201 of them, and read each one top to bottom. Not a sample, and not the ones I happened to remember. Every thread, sorted by what actually happened in it rather than what I'd hoped was happening.

What happened in 201 starred threads

Each bar is out of 201. A + means at least that many.

Positive replies

from cold outreach



0
0%

Genuine engagement

the company I call Quest



1
under 1%

Auto-replies

bots, counted as
engagement for too long



18
9%

Explicit rejections

a real person saying no



35+
at least 17%

Wrong audience

recruiters, filled roles, “no
agencies” bios



50+
at least 25%

Total silence

no reply of any kind



70+
at least 35%

Count before you rewrite

When outreach isn't working, the obvious move is to rewrite the email. New subject line. Shorter body. A sharper first line. It feels productive, because the email is the part you control.

It's the wrong first move. It assumes the email is the problem, and you can't know that until you've counted.

Look at the count again. 50+ of those emails went to people who were never going to hire me, however good the copy was. No subject line fixes that. 18 of the replies were robots, which means the reply rate I'd been watching was wrong. And some of the 35+ people who said no heard from me again anyway. None of that is a copy problem.

Counting honestly comes down to three rules:

- An auto-reply is not a reply.
- A "no" is not a "maybe later".
- Silence is not "still in play". It's silence.

Get those wrong and every number you look at afterwards is fiction. Get them right and the real problems line up in order. Mine did. There were five, and the email itself wasn't one of them.

What actually went wrong

In order of how much damage each one did.

1. I was writing to the wrong people

This was the biggest cause, and it wasn't close.

Too much of my prospecting ran on "hiring" posts. Say a company posts that it's hiring a React Native developer. That reads like a buying signal: there's app work, and there's a gap. So I'd write to whoever posted it.

The problem is who posts those. Often it's a recruiter, whose job is to fill a seat with a person, not hand a project to a studio. Some of the roles were already filled by the time my email landed. Some of the people I wrote to said "no agencies" in their bio, in plain text, and I hadn't looked.

That's where the 50+ come from. Every one of those emails was dead before I wrote the first word. I was messaging job posters and recruiters while the people who actually decide, the founders and CTOs, were a click away. I never checked who was actually behind the post.

The fix is almost embarrassing. Before writing, open the profile and ask one question: can this person say yes to the work? Founder, CTO, head of product: yes. Recruiter: no. Job post showing "No longer accepting applications": the gap is closed. Bio says "no agencies": believe it.

2. I counted auto-replies as engagement

18 of the replies in my threads were automatic. Out-of-office notices. “We’ve received your message.” Ticket-system acknowledgements.

For too long, they sat in my tracking as replies. It’s an easy mistake, because an auto-reply arrives exactly like a real one: a new message in the thread, from their domain, sitting in your inbox. It feels like movement.

It isn’t. A bot confirming delivery is not a person reading your email. Counting it does real damage, too, because it inflates the one number that’s supposed to tell you whether anything is working. My reply rate looked healthier than it was, so I had less reason to question the targeting. That was the actual problem.

They’re easy to separate once you decide to. Most say so in the subject line: “Automatic reply”, “Out of office”. Many also carry an `Auto-Submitted` header, which you can see in Gmail under “Show original”. Filter them out before you calculate anything.

3. Generic follow-ups killed warm threads

This is the expensive one, because it wastes the rarest thing in outbound: a thread where someone already cares.

A technical founder had told me something specific on one of my threads. My next message was a generic “just following up”.

He replied: “you didn’t read our direction.”

He was right. Whether I’d skimmed his message or read it and failed to show it doesn’t matter. From his side, it’s the same thing. He’d handed me exactly what a good follow-up needs, and I sent something I could have sent to anyone.

A warm thread means someone has already given you their attention. A generic follow-up spends that attention and gives nothing back.

4. I kept writing to people who had said no

35+ people told me no, in words. Some of them still got a third message from me. Some got a fourth.

I hadn’t decided to push past a no. My tracking was scattered across too many places, and none of them said “closed”. So a thread that had ended looked exactly like one that was waiting.

From the other side, it looks worse than pushy. It looks like you don’t read your own inbox. Anyone who has received a follow-up to their own “not interested” knows how that lands, and they remember your name for the wrong reason.

5. My deliverability was quietly decaying

The last cause is the least visible. My sends went out 10–15 seconds apart, from a mailbox with no warm-up. Hard bounces and spam flags piled up over time.

None of that sends you a notification. It compounds. Each bounce and each spam flag makes the next email a little more likely to land in spam, so fewer people see it, and every other number gets worse without telling you why.

The dull fixes are the real ones. Verify addresses before you send. Space sends by minutes, not seconds. Warm a new mailbox up gradually. Make sure your domain has SPF, DKIM and DMARC set up.

It's last on the list because the first four would have sunk me even with perfect deliverability. But it made all four of them worse.

The fix, part one: find people who've said it out loud

Targeting by title gives you everyone who could buy. “CTO, 11 to 50 people, SaaS” is a list of thousands, and almost none of them are thinking about your problem this month.

So I stopped searching for titles and started searching for what people say when they're in the middle of it. Phrases like:

- “redesigning our site”
- “website is live”
- “our site is so slow”

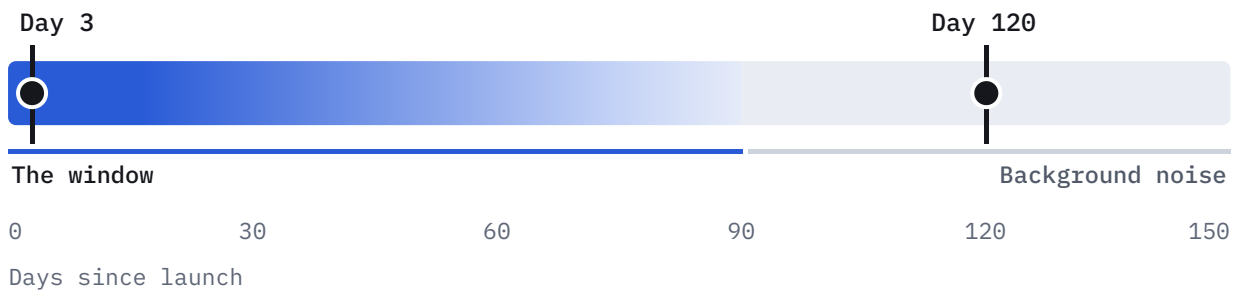
Each of those is someone telling the whole internet that they're thinking about exactly the thing I work on, right now. That isn't a lead list. It's a queue of people with an open question.

It also quietly fixes cause number one. Recruiters post about roles. People don't post “our site is so slow” on behalf of a company they don't work for, so a stated signal tends to come from someone on the inside. You still check the profile, but the odds start in your favor.

The 0–90 day window

Timing matters as much as the phrase. A company that has just launched is paying close attention. They're watching the site, reading feedback, fixing what breaks. That attention fades. At around 90 days the launch stops being news, even internally, and site performance becomes background noise.

The same email, sent on day 3 and on day 120 after a launch



DAY 3

A note about their load time lands in a conversation they're already having.

DAY 120

The same note reads like a stranger pointing at something they've stopped thinking about.

Illustrative: the fade is a judgement, not measured data.

So reaching out on day 3 and reaching out on day 120 are two different emails, even with identical copy. On day 3, a note about their mobile load time lands in the middle of a conversation they're already having. On day 120, the same note is a stranger pointing at something they stopped thinking about months ago.

The fix, part two: audit first, then write

Once I have a signal, I don't write anything until I've looked at the thing they actually made.

The process:

- 1 **Visit the domain.** Their site, on a phone, the way their customers see it.
- 2 **Run a PageSpeed check.** It takes about 90 seconds.
- 3 **Screenshot the finding.** One finding, cropped tight.
- 4 **Personalize with one or two specific issues.** Never a laundry list.
- 5 **Send within hours, not days.**

Each step earns its place. The visit means you know what they launched before you comment on it. PageSpeed gives you something concrete and checkable instead of "I noticed a few issues". The screenshot makes it their site, not your opinion. One or two issues, because a list of twelve reads like an automated report, and one reads like a person looked. Hours, not days, because the signal is fresh and sites change. Wait a week and they may have fixed the thing you're about to point out.

The audit is also a small proof of competence. It's roughly the first step I'd take with a paying client. So the prospect gets a real piece of the work before I've claimed anything about myself.

The one email that worked

Out of 201 threads, one turned into a real conversation: a company I'll call Quest.

The email that did it had no pitch in it and no call ask. It asked three specific technical questions about a decision that was visible on their site. The kind of questions you only ask if you actually looked, and actually want to know.

They answered in detail. Then they offered the call themselves.

Compare that with a real email of mine that got zero replies:

Hope you're doing well! I help founders build apps fast and affordably — would love to grab 15 minutes if you're open to it.

Read it as the person receiving it. "Hope you're doing well" is filler that announces "cold email" before anything else. "I help founders build apps fast and affordably" is a claim with no proof, and every studio on earth makes it. "Grab 15 minutes" asks for their time before giving them a single reason to spend it.

The Quest email turned all of that around. It made no claims, so there was nothing to doubt. It asked questions only someone competent would think to ask, so the competence was shown, not asserted. And it didn't ask for their time at all, which is exactly why they offered it.

The lesson: a specific, genuine technical observation is the pitch. It proves you know what you're doing before you've said a word about yourself.

The two-touch cap

The last fix is structural, and it's the one I trust most.

I built a CRM where a prospect cannot receive a third touch. Not "shouldn't". Cannot. There's no button for it. After the second touch, the only things you can do with a thread are record a reply, record a no, or close it.

This is deliberately not a willpower rule. Rules you have to remember fail exactly when the pipeline looks thin and you're tempted to squeeze one more message out of an old thread. A button that doesn't exist can't be pressed on a bad day.

It fixed two things at once.

First, the scattered tracking. Every prospect lives in one place. Every touch is logged. A "no" closes the thread for good. Nobody gets a follow-up to their own rejection, because there's no follow-up left to send.

Second, it changed what I write. When touch two is the last one, "just following up" wastes the only follow-up you get. So touch two has to earn its place with something new: a finding I didn't have

before, a change on their site, an answer to something they said. If I have nothing new, I don't send it. The thread closes, and that's fine.

Where to start

If your outreach isn't working, don't open the email template first. Open your sent folder and count your last 50 threads. Honestly: auto-replies aren't replies, a no is a no, silence is silence. Then look at who you were writing to.

My bet is the email isn't your biggest problem either.

The tools I built for this are on the [tools page](#). There's an in-browser version of the two-touch CRM. No login, and it really won't let you log a third touch. There's also a prospect scorer: give it the signal, the company size and the days since the trigger, and it tells you whether a prospect is worth an audit today. Both are free.

What failed, and how to check your own outreach

Five root causes, worst first. Each ends with a check you can run on your own threads before you touch your email copy.

Het Soni · outreach.soniconsultancyservices.com/articles/what-failed/

When outreach stops working, the instinct is to rewrite the email. Not yet. Run this first.

These are the five things that broke mine, worst first, from an audit of 201 of my own threads. Each ends with a one-line check. Open your sent folder and go through them in order. Fixing number five while number one is still broken is wasted effort.

1. Wrong targeting

The biggest cause by a distance. 50+ of my messages went to people who were never going to buy: recruiters, job posters, roles that were already filled, people whose bio said “no agencies”.

The pattern was hiring posts. A company hiring looks like a signal, but the person behind the post is often a recruiter whose job is to fill a seat, not to hire a studio. I wasn’t checking who was actually behind the post.

The fix is one question, asked before you write: can this person say yes to the work?



CHECK YOURSELF

Open your last 20 sent threads and mark every recipient who couldn’t personally say yes. That’s your wrong-audience rate.

2. Auto-reply traps

18 of the “replies” in my threads were automatic: out-of-office notices, ticket confirmations, “we’ve received your message”. For too long, they counted as engagement.

That’s worse than it sounds. It inflates your reply rate, which is the number you use to decide whether anything is wrong. A bot confirming delivery isn’t a person reading your email.

☐ CHECK YOURSELF

Search your replies for “out of office”, “automatic reply” and “auto-reply”. Subtract them and recalculate your reply rate.

3. Generic follow-ups on warm threads

The most expensive mistake on the list, because it wastes the rarest thing you have: someone who already engaged.

A technical founder had told me something specific on a thread. I followed up with “just following up”. He replied: “you didn’t read our direction.” A warm thread, spent on nothing.

A follow-up has one job, which is to add something. A new finding, a change on their site, a response to what they said. “Just following up”, “bumping this” and “circling back” add nothing except proof that you didn’t read the thread.

☐ CHECK YOURSELF

Read your last five follow-ups. If any of them could go to a different prospect unchanged, it’s generic.

4. Touching dead leads

35+ people told me no, in plain words. Some still got a third message from me. Some got a fourth. My tracking was scattered, so nothing marked those threads as closed.

That isn’t persistence. To the person who said no, it reads as not listening, and they remember your name for the wrong reason.

What fixed it for me was structural, not a resolution: a [CRM where a third touch doesn’t exist](#), and where a “no” closes the thread for good.

☐ CHECK YOURSELF

Search your inbox for “not interested” and “no thanks”, then check whether you wrote to any of those people again.

5. Deliverability

The quietest cause. My emails went out 10-15 seconds apart, from a mailbox with no warm-up. Hard bounces and spam flags stacked up, and each one made the next email a little more likely to land

in spam.

You don't get a notification when this happens. You get a slow slide in how many people even see your email, which drags down every other number on this list without telling you why.

The unglamorous basics: verify addresses before you send, space sends by minutes rather than seconds, warm up a new mailbox gradually, and set up SPF, DKIM and DMARC on your domain.



CHECK YOURSELF

Find your bounce rate for the last month. If you can't, that's the first thing to fix.

Reading your results

Fix them in order. If number one is broken, nothing downstream matters. A perfect email to a recruiter is still an email to a recruiter.

If one through four check out and replies are still thin, then it's time to look at the copy, and [the Quest email](#) is a good place to start. The full story behind all five, with every number, is in [the audit](#).

Search for what people say, not what they're called

A job title tells you who could buy. A sentence someone posted this week tells you who's thinking about it right now.

Het Soni · outreach.soniconsultancyservices.com/articles/signal-based-targeting/

Most prospecting starts with a title filter. Founder or CTO, 11 to 50 people, some industry. Search, export, write.

What you get is everyone who *could* buy from you. Almost none of them are thinking about your problem this month. You're interrupting people at random and calling it targeting.

Signal-based targeting flips the order. You search for the words people use when they're in the middle of the thing you do, and only then look at who said them.

Phrases worth searching

The three that started it for me were “redesigning our site”, “website is live” and “our site is so slow”. Here are more from the same three families. Swap in your own niche: the phrases change, the method doesn't.

Just launched. The site or app is new and they're watching it.

- “website is live”
- “we just launched”
- “just went live”
- “our new site is up”

Rebuild under way. A decision is being made right now.

- “redesigning our site”
- “rebuilding our website”
- “new website coming soon”
- “migrating our site”

Stated pain. They've already diagnosed a problem, in public.

- “our site is so slow”

- “site keeps going down”
- “app keeps crashing”
- “checkout is broken”

Running the search on LinkedIn

- 1 **Type the phrase in straight double quotes** in the main search bar: `"website is live"`.
Quotes force an exact match. LinkedIn only honors straight quotes, so curly ones pasted from a doc won't work.
- 2 **Switch the results to Posts.**
- 3 **Sort by Latest**, so you see today's posts rather than the most-liked one from last year.
- 4 **Set Date posted to Past week**, or Past 24 hours for busy phrases.
- 5 **Combine phrases with an uppercase OR**: `"website is live" OR "we just launched"`.
LinkedIn only treats AND, OR and NOT as operators when they're in capitals.

Then, before anything else, open the author's profile. “We just launched” might come from the founder. It might also come from a social media manager, or from the agency that built the site, which makes them a competitor rather than a prospect.

The same phrases work in Google: `site:linkedin.com/posts "website is live"`, with the date range set under Tools.

Why intent beats titles

Timing. A title stays true for years. A signal is true this week, so it tells you when to write, not just who to write to.

Relevance. You don't have to guess whether they care about site speed. They told you.

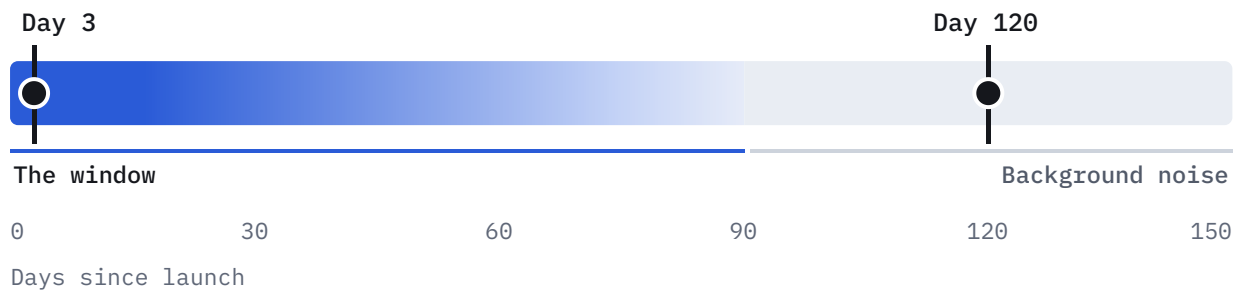
A reason to write. Your first line is a response to something they said, not an interruption.

There's a quieter fourth reason: signals filter out the wrong audience. Searching for anyone “hiring” drags in recruiters and roles that are already filled. That was the single biggest leak in my own outreach: 50+ of 201 threads went to people who were never going to buy. Nobody posts “our site is so slow” on behalf of a company they don't work for.

The 0–90 day window

A signal isn't just a phrase. It's a phrase with a timestamp, and the timestamp matters as much as the words. Here's how I think about the life of a launch.

The same email, sent on day 3 and on day 120 after a launch



DAY 3

A note about their load time lands in a conversation they're already having.

DAY 120

The same note reads like a stranger pointing at something they've stopped thinking about.

Illustrative: the fade is a judgement, not measured data.

Read it left to right.

Day 0, the launch. The site goes live. The team is watching everything: analytics, feedback, whatever's breaking. Performance is a live topic, because they've just put weeks into this and want it to land.

The first few weeks. The best time to write. A note about their mobile load time lands in the middle of a conversation they're already having. They may already suspect the thing you found, so your email is a second opinion, not an unwelcome first mention.

Toward day 90. Attention fades as other priorities come back. The site is "done", even if it isn't. Your finding still matters, but it's competing with the rest of the roadmap.

After day 90. Background noise. The launch isn't news anymore, even inside the company.

That's why reaching out on day 3 versus day 120 is a different email even with identical copy. The words don't change. What changes is whether they land on an open question or a closed one.

The window isn't a law. A company still visibly struggling with performance on day 150 is a live signal. But by then the signal is the struggle, not the launch. Score what's true today.

Audit first, then write

Before you write a word, look at the thing they just made. Five steps you can run today, and a template for sounding like a person instead of a mail merge.

Het Soni · outreach.soniconsultancyservices.com/articles/audit-first-method/

The audit-first method has one rule: before you write anything, look at the thing they just made. For me that's usually their website. For you it might be their app or their signup flow.

1. Visit the domain

Open the site the way their customers do, and start on your phone. You're looking for two things: what they're proud of (the launch, the redesign, the new feature) and what's visibly off. Don't catalogue everything. You need one thing.

2. Run a PageSpeed check

Go to [PageSpeed Insights](#), paste the URL and wait. It takes about 90 seconds.

Start with the mobile results. You'll see two kinds of data:

- **Real-user data** at the top, if the site gets enough traffic. New sites often don't, so don't be surprised if this part is empty.
- **Lab data** below it: one test run, with a performance score and a list of diagnostics.

Skip the score; it's the least useful thing on the page. Go to the diagnostics and look for one finding that's specific, visible and easy to explain to someone non-technical:

- **The biggest element is slow to appear.** PageSpeed names the Largest Contentful Paint element, which is often the hero image.
- **Images far bigger than they're shown.** A full-resolution photo shipped to a phone screen.
- **Layout shift.** Content jumping around while the page loads, with the elements responsible listed.
- **Render-blocking requests.** Scripts or stylesheets holding the whole page up.

Pick the one with the clearest consequence for their business.

3. Screenshot the finding

Crop to the one finding. No full-page captures, no twelve red rows.

- **Mac:** Cmd + Shift + 4, then drag.
- **Windows:** Win + Shift + S.
- **Chrome or Edge:** open DevTools, press Cmd/Ctrl + Shift + P, type “screenshot” and pick *Capture area screenshot* or *Capture node screenshot*.

The screenshot is your evidence. On LinkedIn it can go straight into the message. On a first cold email, think twice before attaching anything: an attachment from an unknown sender gives spam filters one more reason to bin you. Describe the finding in words, and keep the screenshot ready for when they reply “what do you mean?”

4. Write one or two issues, never a list

This is where most “personalized” emails fall apart, with a sentence that could be pasted into anyone’s email:

I noticed a few performance issues on your website that might be affecting your conversions.

That’s a canned insert. It names nothing, proves nothing, and every agency sends it.

The shape to aim for has four parts, in this order:

- 1 **What you looked at.** The page, and why you were there.
- 2 **What you saw.** One element, one number at most.
- 3 **Why it matters to them.** In their terms, not yours.
- 4 **A question you actually want answered.**

Here’s a version for a made-up site:

Saw the new site went live last week. On mobile, the hero photo is the last thing to show up: PageSpeed flags it as the largest element, at around four seconds. On a page whose whole job is the sign-up button underneath it, that’s a long wait. Is the full-size image being sent to phones, or is something else holding it up?

Four rules keep it from reading like an insert:

- **Use their words.** If their launch post said “rebuilt from scratch”, say “rebuilt from scratch”.
- **Name the thing.** “The hero photo on mobile”, not “some images”.
- **One number, maximum.** Two start to read like a report.
- **End on a real question.** If you don’t care about the answer, they’ll notice.

Then run the test: could this paragraph be pasted into an email to a different company? If yes, it’s still an insert. Rewrite it until it can’t be.

Two issues is the ceiling. A third finding doesn't make you look thorough. It turns the email into a report, and nobody replies to a report.

5. Send within hours, not days

The audit has a shelf life. The signal is freshest right now (more on that in [the 0-90 day window](#)), and sites change. Wait a week and they may have fixed the thing you're pointing at, which makes your email wrong on arrival.

So audit when you're ready to send. Don't batch audits on Monday for a Friday send.

Why it works

The audit isn't a trick to get a reply. It's roughly the first step I'd take with a paying client. The prospect gets a small, real piece of the work before you've made a single claim about yourself, and that is the pitch.

The Quest email: three questions, no pitch

Out of 201 threads, one turned into a real conversation. The email asked three technical questions and pitched nothing.

Het Soni · outreach.soniconsultancyservices.com/articles/the-quest-email/

Of the 201 outreach threads I audited, one turned into a genuine conversation. The company is one I'll call Quest.

The email that did it had no pitch and no call ask. It asked three specific technical questions about a decision that was visible on their site. They answered in detail, and then they offered the call themselves.

Here it is next to an email of mine that got zero replies. One note first: Quest's email was about Quest's site, so I'm not reprinting it. The version below keeps its exact shape, an opening that names a visible decision followed by three questions and nothing else, applied to a made-up company. The generic email is real and verbatim.

The generic email

REAL, VERBATIM

✗ Zero replies

1 Hope you're doing well!

Filler. It tells them nothing and costs them a line. It's also how every cold email opens, so it marks yours as one before they've read anything else.

2 I help founders build apps fast and affordably —

A claim with no proof, and the same one every studio makes. "Fast" and "affordably" are words, not evidence.

3 would love to grab 15 minutes if you're open to it.

The whole point of the email, and the part they have the least reason to agree to. It asks for their time before giving them one reason to spend it.

The Quest-shaped email

SAME STRUCTURE, MADE-UP COMPANY

✓ Answered in detail, call offered

1 Subject: your PWA-first launch

Names the thing. They know what it's about before they open it.

2 Saw you launched as an installable web app instead of going native first.

A visible decision, stated neutrally. It proves you looked, and it doesn't assume it was a mistake.

3 Was PWA-first a deliberate call, or a stage-one thing until the product settles?

Question one asks why. It assumes they had a reason, because they usually did.

4 How are you handling push notifications on iOS? Relying on people adding it to their home screen, or skipping push for now?

Question two goes where the decision bites. Only someone who knows the platform would ask it, so the competence is shown rather than claimed.

5 And is a native app on the roadmap, or does the web app carry you for a while?

Question three asks about their direction, which is the thing people most like to explain.

6 Het

No pitch, no calendar link, no "I help founders". The signature is the only thing about me in the email.

Why the second one works

It makes no claims, so there's nothing to doubt. The generic email asks the reader to believe "fast and affordably". The Quest-shaped one asks them to believe nothing. It just shows its working.

It proves competence instead of asserting it. Anyone can type "I build apps". Not everyone knows where a PWA-first launch gets awkward. The questions are the credential.

It asks for something easy to give. Answering a good question about your own product is easy, and a little flattering. Booking a call with a stranger is neither.

It leaves the next move to them. That's why the call came from Quest's side. People who offer a call turn up curious. People who get asked for one turn up guarded, if they turn up at all.

Writing your own

- 1 **Find a visible decision, not a flaw.** A platform choice, a pricing structure, a checkout flow, a stack. A decision gives you something to ask about. A flaw only gives you something to criticize.
- 2 **Ask three questions you'd ask a peer.** Why they chose it, where it bites, what's next.
- 3 **Delete everything about you.** Your services, your clients, your calendar link. If the questions are good, they'll ask who you are.
- 4 **Only ask what you actually want to know.** Faked curiosity reads as faked. "Genuine" isn't decoration here. It's the part they respond to.

The lesson, in one line: a specific, genuine technical observation is the pitch.

Use it

The two tools from the system run free in your browser, no login:

- [The two-touch CRM](#): two touches per prospect, then the thread closes. There is no button for a third.
- [The prospect scorer](#): signal, company size and days since the trigger, scored 1 to 10 with the reason.

New teardowns go out by email when they're written. Sign up at outreach.soniconsultancyservices.com.

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